

Report Name

African Leadership Academy (ALA)_South Africa_2021-22_3-month Report

Fellowship Organization

African Leadership Academy (ALA)

Fellowship City

Johannesburg

Fellowship Country

South Africa

Fellowship Start Date

2021-09-01

Fellowship End Date

2022-08-31

Your Fellowship Position and Workplace

What is your fellowship title/role?

Business Development Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

Developing data systems and dashboards to track program outcomes

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Agree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Yes

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

The organization ran a thorough onboarding over the first week. My supervisor walked me through existing projects and introduced me to the full team.

Describe a representative day at work.

Morning: review emails and prepare for meetings. 9am-12pm: attend team meetings and work on current projects. Lunch with colleagues. 1pm-5pm: focused project work and stakeholder calls. Evenings are generally free.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

45

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Effective

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

1) Developed a comprehensive monitoring framework for the organization's flagship program. 2) Produced a strategic research report that has been shared with senior leadership and external partners.

What is your office environment like?

Open plan office with approximately 20-30 staff. Collaborative culture with strong emphasis on teamwork. Good facilities including reliable internet.

To whom do you report?

Director of Programs

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Yes

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year.

- Strengthen my research and analytical writing capabilities - Expand my professional network in the African development sector - Develop fluency in the local language to a conversational level - Lead at least one independent project from design to completion - Build skills in organizational strategy and program design

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response.

My academic background and previous experience prepared me well for the core responsibilities. Some aspects of working in this specific context required adjustment and learning on the job.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I flew from my home country to Johannesburg via a connection. The organization provided information about the journey in advance.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

Volunteer Visa

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

VFS Global center

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

Before arriving

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

No cost, covered by organization

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

Covered by the organization

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

Use VFS Global rather than the embassy directly, much faster

How was your arrival and first week in your host country?

Arrival was smooth. The organization arranged transport from the airport. The first week was overwhelming in a positive way with so much new information and people to meet.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

Self arranged with organization subsidy. I rent a room in a shared house near the office.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Urban

Please describe your living environment

Safe neighborhood, walking distance to shops. Gated property with security guard.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

I use Uber for most travel as public transport is not reliable or safe. The organization also has a shuttle for staff.

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

The weather in South Africa varies throughout the year. Currently in a warm season with occasional rain.

What are the local languages in your community?

The main local languages plus English which is widely used in professional settings.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

Smart casual for work. Outside work, standard casual clothing is appropriate. Modest dress is advisable in more traditional settings.

How have you been spending your free time?

Exploring Johannesburg and day trips to the Magaliesberg mountains. The Apartheid Museum is essential. Weekend trips to Cape Town were a highlight.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

I stay connected with family and friends through regular video calls. Socially I have built good relationships with colleagues and other fellows in the area.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

Yes

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I always use Uber rather than walking or taking public transport at night. I avoid wearing jewelry or displaying my phone in public. Crime is real but manageable with awareness.

What has been your experience with crime so far?

I have not experienced any crime directly. I maintain awareness of my surroundings and follow local advice about safe practices.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town.

Johannesburg has a manageable security situation for those who take appropriate precautions. I feel comfortable in my daily movements.

Monthly Budget

Rent

0 ZAR

Transportation

2000 ZAR

Groceries

1500 ZAR

Eating Out

2000 ZAR

Entertainment

1500 ZAR

Other

500 ZAR

Reflections and Feedback

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals?

I am making good progress on all of my goals. The goal around building local professional relationships has been the most fulfilling. I am on track overall.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

Minor frustrations around navigating the racial dynamics and understanding the local context took time. Overall very satisfied with the experience.

How have you dealt with culture shock?

The inequality is striking and takes time to process emotionally. The racial dynamics are complex and different from what I expected. Getting involved in campus life helped enormously.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

How much I would love Johannesburg. It has a reputation for danger but I found a vibrant, creative, and exciting city.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

Navigating the racial dynamics and understanding the local context took time. The economic inequality is emotionally difficult to process.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

- Home cooked food from my family - Close friends and familiar social environment - Reliable infrastructure and predictability

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

- The natural beauty - The sense of community and warmth of people - The depth of experience and personal growth

Have you had your introductory meeting with your Alumni Mentor?

Yes

How often do you and your mentor check in?

Monthly

The PiAf Fellows Whatsapp Community has helped me build a sense of community with my cohort.

Agree

How often do you engage with the PiAf Fellows Whatsapp Community?

Several times a week

PiAf's Pre-Departure Orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Somewhat Agree

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

The orientation was helpful for general preparation but some country specific information about visas and daily life would have been valuable.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post?

More specific visa guidance for each country would have reduced stress significantly. A country specific guidebook written by past fellows would be extremely helpful.

Are you receiving sufficient support, materials and information from the Princeton in Africa office?

Yes, the team has been responsive and supportive throughout.

Programming Ideas

A structured peer mentorship system connecting fellows in similar countries or sectors. More opportunities for fellows to share experiences across the cohort.